



ENDLESS FORMS MOST BEAUTIFUL AND MOST WONDERFUL HAVE BEEN, AND ARE BEING, EVOLVED

DARWIN PUBLISHES *ON THE ORIGIN OF SPECIES* (1859)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Scientific advance

BEFORE

1831–1836 The voyage of the HMS *Beagle* takes the young naturalist Charles Darwin around the world.

AFTER

1860 Thomas Huxley defends Darwin from an attack by the established Anglican church.

1863 Gregor Mendel demonstrates how genetics influence all plant life.

1871 Darwin's *The Descent of Man* advances the view of sexual selection, whereby the most successful members of a species are naturally attracted to perpetuate the species.

1953 Discovery of DNA demonstrates how traits are passed on genetically.

Perhaps the most important scientist of the 19th century, Charles Darwin originally intended to follow his father into medicine and was subsequently sent to Cambridge to train as an Anglican cleric. Endlessly curious, he was interested in almost any scientific question.

The publication of his book *On the Origin of Species* (1859) introduced a new scientific understanding of what gradually came to be known as evolution. In the book, Darwin asked a fundamental

Geologists begin to understand that **the Earth has existed** for previously unimaginable **eons of time**.



It became clear to scientists that the Earth had undergone a series of **immense changes and extinctions**.



Charles Darwin publishes *On the Origin of Species*.



Darwin's book explains the **diversity of animal species** and posits that all life on Earth is **related to a common ancestor**.



Modern science decisively reinforces the evidence and conclusions presented in **Darwin's landmark text**.

question. The world teems with plant and animal life: where and what had it come from? How had it been created?

Darwin was far from the first to propose that a process of change over vast periods had produced this diversity, but he was the first to suggest an explanatory theme, which he called "natural selection."